

13 questions for the future of crowd work

In 2013, a paper born at CrowdCamp asked: *“Can we foresee a future crowd workplace in which we would want our children to participate?”* It mapped twelve research areas. AI has since changed most of them. Here is the question we would ask about each one today, plus a thirteenth the paper left out.

Why now: Amazon Mechanical Turk shuts down on September 30, 2026, the last day of this conference.

WORK PROCESS

01 WORKFLOW

One person with agentic AI now matches a hackathon team of five. Do we still need to decompose work across people?

02 TASK ASSIGNMENT

When agents take most tasks, what is left to assign to people, and who decides?

03 HIERARCHY

Who manages whom when a team includes agents?

04 REAL-TIME RESPONSE

Models answer instantly. When do we still need people on call?

05 SYNCHRONOUS COLLABORATION

If one person with AI can do a team's work, why do we still work together?

06 QUALITY CONTROL

Who catches the AI's failures, and how do teams agree on how far to trust its output?

COMPUTATION

07 CROWDS GUIDING AIS

Did they? And who holds the harness now when AI fails, bug-bounty style?

08 AIS GUIDING CROWDS

AI now leads much of the work. Where do people still steer?

09 PLATFORMS

MTurk shuts down on September 30, 2026. What replaces it, and what do workers get?

WORKERS

10 JOB DESIGN

What work next to AI would we be proud to see our children do?

11 REPUTATION AND CREDENTIALS

How do you build a track record when an AI did half the work?

12 MOTIVATION AND REWARDS

What should overseeing AI pay, and what happens when tokens cost what they really cost?

NEW IN 2026

13 GOVERNANCE AND THE SOCIAL CONTRACT

Who writes that contract? Can crowds organize the way labor unions once did?



Pick one. Get your route.

1. Scan the code and choose the question you care about.
2. Get the sessions, talks and posters that match it, Monday to Wednesday.
3. Ask your question in Q&A, then leave a comment, question or criticism on the talk, and say when you think you will live in that future.

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